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OnePlus will focus on smartphones only, no more drones

In conversation with the co-founder of OnePlus about the OnePlus 2 and the company's plans for India

◀ Carl Pei,
Co-Founder, OnePlus.

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OnePlus has always been looked at as an enthusiast's brand. Do you plan to change that and cater to the mass market?

Carl: From the start, we never had a volume or market share goal. We simply weren't satisfied with what was available, and wanted to create products good enough for ourselves to use. For some, going mass market means creating a \$100 smartphone. We'll never do that. If we ever become mass market, it's going to be because we have the best products, not the cheapest products.

Before the OnePlus 2, no one really tackled the Snapdragon 810's heating issues effectively. How did you deal with it?

Carl: The Qualcomm Snapdragon 810 is the best processor for this generation of flagships. You can see people settling with the 808, but in reality, there's still a performance gap. We have taken many precautions to prevent excess warming on the OnePlus 2, and our engineers have worked closely with Qualcomm's to integrate and fine-tune both hardware and software. On the hardware side, we've layered both thermal gel and graphite sheets across different areas of the phone. This ensures that warming generated from the processors will dissipate evenly,

as opposed to being concentrated and leading to performance issues. On the software side, we've built up quite an engineering team in Taipei over the past year. Our Performance Lab has invented a bunch of ways of managing CPUs more efficiently, and we have filed patents for these technologies. This is the real magic behind why the OnePlus 2 is one of the best performing 810 flagships. We'll be going through this in more depth, later.

It took OnePlus some time to enter India, but now it's amongst the important markets. What challenges did you face here?

Carl: The invite only model in the beginning was perceived as a hindrance but over time, more and more Indian users are understanding it and increasingly becoming comfortable with our sales model. The other challenge was the supply constraints and service issues faced in the beginning but the initial bottlenecks have since been resolved.

Does the Indian market differ from others?

Carl: I believe that differences in geography are fading with the growth of social media and the consumer internet. Today, trend conscious people around the world are more and more similar. I don't subscribe to the notion that Indian consumers are different from their American counterparts, and need product customizations

tailored to the local market. Consumers, irrespective of geography, are smart enough to tell a great product apart from an average one.

OxygenOS has stuck to more of a stock Android appearance so far. Will this change?

Carl: We are acutely aware of the needs of our customers. Today, Material Design features a great user experience. But does it mark the end of the advancement of human-computer interaction design? Probably not. There are always ways of improving things – at the same time, it's easy to add things, but hard to actually improve things. With OxygenOS, we have been trying to achieve balance by practicing both addition and subtraction.

You have shown the inclination to make more products than just smartphones. What can we expect going forward?

Carl: It's true that we've had a bunch of new categories in development, but luckily, they have all been scrapped. The decision to initiate R&D on those categories were done at a time when we were young and unfocused. We believe that only extreme focus can yield hero products, and focusing on a bunch of categories will only lead to mediocrity. It's easy to make a good enough product, but it's the final 10% that makes all the difference. 